

Day 2 — The Two Pakṣas

Module: Moon Phases & Tithi · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students will define *śukla pakṣa* and *kṛṣṇa pakṣa*, identify the two anchor days *amāvasyā* and *pūrṇimā*, and place yesterday's observed Moon shape into one of the two pakṣas.

Materials

- Yesterday's exit-ticket slips (skim before class)
- Board with two columns ready: *śukla pakṣa* and *kṛṣṇa pakṣa*
- The white ball and torch (for a 2-min recall demo)
- Notebooks

Vocabulary introduced today

- *pakṣa* (IAST: pakṣa; lit. “wing, side, fortnight”) — half of a lunar month. There are exactly two pakṣas in every lunar month.
- *śukla pakṣa* (IAST: śukla-pakṣa; lit. “bright fortnight”) — the waxing half: the Moon grows from invisible to full.
- *kṛṣṇa pakṣa* (IAST: kṛṣṇa-pakṣa; lit. “dark fortnight”) — the waning half: the Moon shrinks from full back to invisible.
- *amāvasyā* (IAST: amāvasyā; lit. “dwelling-together”) — new moon; the Moon and Sun are in the same direction in the sky.
- *pūrṇimā* (IAST: pūrṇimā; lit. “fullness”) — full moon; Moon directly opposite the Sun.

Lesson flow

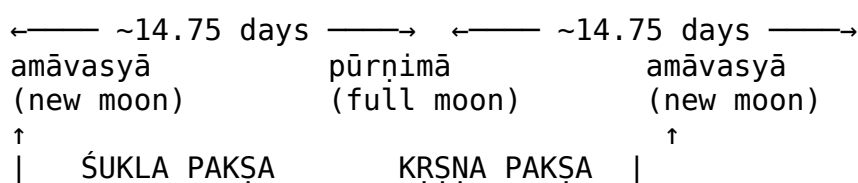
Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily prompt: “*Did you see the Moon last night? What shape?*” — 2 students share.
- Quick recall: ring the question from yesterday's demo. “*Why does the Moon change shape?*” (Sun lights half; we see different fractions as it orbits.)
- One-sentence reminder: “*The full cycle takes about 29.5 days — the synodic month.*”

Core (20 min)

1. Split the cycle in half.

Draw on the board:



	(waxing /	(waning /	
	"bright")	"dark")	

- The fortnight from *amāvasyā* to *pūrṇimā* — when the Moon is **growing** — is the *śukla pakṣa* (“bright fortnight”). The visible lit fraction is increasing each night.
 - The fortnight from *pūrṇimā* to *amāvasyā* — when the Moon is **shrinking** — is the *kṛṣṇa pakṣa* (“dark fortnight”). The visible lit fraction is decreasing each night.
2. **Why these names?** *Śukla* (शुक्ल) means “bright, white”; *kṛṣṇa* (कृष्ण) means “dark, black.” Naming the fortnights by the direction the brightness is heading — toward full or toward new — is precise and useful.
 3. **A common confusion to head off:** Neither pakṣa is “good” or “bad.” Both are simply astronomical halves of the lunar cycle. Some festivals fall in *śukla* (e.g. Rāma Navamī, Vaiṣṇava Ekādaśī), some in *kṛṣṇa* (e.g. Janmāṣṭamī, Mahā-śivarātri).
 4. **The two anchor days deserve their names:**
 - *amāvasyā* — literally “dwelling-together.” The Sun and Moon are in the same direction in the sky (Moon is between Earth and Sun-ish, near the same celestial longitude). The Moon is up during the day, invisible against the sky’s brightness.
 - *pūrṇimā* — “fullness.” Moon is opposite the Sun. It rises as the Sun sets, stays up all night, sets as the Sun rises. It is fully illuminated.
 5. **Connecting to yesterday’s diary.** Hold up your own diary — “*I observed last night, it was a thin crescent right after sunset on the western horizon. That’s a waxing crescent — I’m in śukla pakṣa, just a few days after amāvasyā.*”

Have 3 students share theirs: which pakṣa, how do they know?

Activity (15 min) — Sort the shapes

On the board, draw 8 Moon shapes (you sketched these yesterday in the demo). Number them 1–8 in random order.

In pairs, students:

1. Copy the 8 shapes (small, in a row) in their notebook.
2. Label each as *śukla* or *kṛṣṇa* — and give a reason.
3. Number them in the order they would appear across a lunar month, starting from *amāvasyā*.

Discuss with a different pair (3 min): did you disagree on any? Which?

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Exit ticket (1 min):** “What is the difference between *śukla pakṣa* and *kṛṣṇa pakṣa*? Use one sentence.”
- Preview Day 3: “Tomorrow we name the 15 days within each pakṣa — the *tithis*.”

Student-facing content

A lunar month has two halves — two *pakṣas*.

Sanskrit	English	Direction the Moon is heading
<i>śukla pakṣa</i>	bright fortnight	growing — new moon → full moon
<i>kṛṣṇa pakṣa</i>	dark fortnight	shrinking — full moon → new moon

Two anchor days bookend the pakṣas: - *amāvasyā* (new moon) — Moon invisible, “dwelling together with” the Sun - *pūrṇimā* (full moon) — Moon fully lit, opposite the Sun

Neither pakṣa is “good” or “bad.” They are astronomical halves of the cycle.

Homework

- Continue the Moon diary. Tonight, add **which pakṣa you are in** to your sketch.
- For Day 3, **memorise the names *amāvasyā* and *pūrṇimā* and the two pakṣa names.**

Differentiation

- One tier up:** Look up the meaning of the words *śukla* and *kṛṣṇa* in any Sanskrit dictionary. Are they used only for the Moon, or in other contexts? (They are general-purpose words for “bright/white” and “dark/black.”)
- One tier down:** Memorise only *amāvasyā* and *pūrṇimā* for now. The pakṣa terms can wait one more day.

Teacher notes

- Watch for the misconception that *kṛṣṇa pakṣa* is “the dark side of the Moon” — these are completely different concepts. *Kṛṣṇa pakṣa* is a fortnight of the calendar; the “far side” of the Moon is a separate thing about which face we always see.
- Pronunciation hint: the ṣ in *pakṣa* is retroflex — closer to English “puk-sha” than “puk-sa.” Don’t worry about perfection; insist on “pakṣa,” not “paksha-aaa.”

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Paraphrase from *Sūrya-siddhānta*, chapter 2 (lunar motion): the lunar month is divided into 30 tithis, distributed 15 each across the two pakṣas. Cited by text name only.